Trick-or-Treating Was a Bribe

The Real History of Halloween · draft 1

15 MINUTE HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 1547 WORDS · ABOUT 10:00

> ***Driving question:*** *How did the most destructive night of the year turn into a candy holiday for little kids?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 The Tear Gas Headline

Tear gas. On Halloween.

This is a real front page from North Dakota, the morning after Halloween, 1933. Look at the headline. "Tear Gas Used to Halt Pranks." The night before, about 300 boys had piled junk cars and garbage in front of the high school. So the police gassed them.

This Saturday, about six in ten American adults will stand at their front door and hand out candy. Around four billion dollars of it.

[curious] So how did *that* turn into *this*?

Here's the short answer. *Trick-or-treating started as a bribe.* And almost everything you think of as Halloween started as a grown-up's plan to stop it.

We'll get to the bribe. And to one Halloween night in Texas that turned parents against the very candy they'd invented to keep the peace.

But first, we need a vegetable. And it's not a pumpkin.

0:58 Turnips and Tipped Outhouses

Ireland, about two hundred years ago. It's Halloween night, and kids are carrying lanterns. They've hollowed out turnips, carved faces into them, and put a candle inside.

[wry] Look at this one. It's in a museum in Ireland. Honestly? Way creepier than a pumpkin.

There were bonfires, and people in disguises. And there was mischief.

You may have heard that Halloween is a two-thousand-year-old Celtic festival called Samhain. Historians actually argue about that. The name comes from a Christian holiday: **All Hallows' Eve**, the night before All Saints' Day. The line back to anything ancient is a lot messier than the internet says.

What we know is how it got to America. In the 1840s, a famine drove more than a million Irish people across the ocean, and they brought their Halloween customs with them. But America had something Ireland didn't. Pumpkins. Big, cheap, and a lot easier to carve than a turnip. So over time, the **jack-o'-lantern** switched vegetables. If you carve a pumpkin this week, you're doing the American upgrade.

The mischief came over too. Gates lifted off their hinges. Windows soaped. Outhouses tipped over. Sometimes, the stories go, with somebody still inside.

And wagons. Somehow, it was always wagons. One Halloween in Newton, Kansas, people woke up to find a wagon on the roof of the lumberyard. For decades, wagons kept turning up on roofs every November first.

Grown-ups mostly shrugged. Boys will be boys. [dry] Which is not, it turns out, a legal defense.

Then came the Great Depression. And the pranks stopped being funny.

2:33 The Worst Halloween

Fargo, North Dakota. Halloween night, 1933. Somebody keeps pulling false fire alarms. Porch lights and streetlamps get shot out. The paper made a point of saying the six boys charged were all from "prominent families."

Across the state, in Bismarck, about 300 boys pile junk cars and garbage in front of the high school. That's when the police bring out the tear gas. That's the headline from the start of this video.

And North Dakota wasn't special. Across the country, Halloween came with smashed windows, pulled-down trolley wires, and streetcar tracks smeared with grease, so the cars slid right past their stops. Some histories call that year *Black Halloween*.

Now stack it up. Teenage boys. No jobs, because it's the Depression. A night when the normal rules don't apply. And towns full of things to break. That means Halloween wasn't really a kids' holiday anymore. *It was a riot in costume.*

Officials in some cities talked about banning it. But how do you ban a night? The kids would come out anyway.

[curious] So if you can't stop Halloween, what do you do?

Some towns came up with a better idea. They decided to pay.

3:46 The Deal

Here's the plan. If teenagers are going to roam the streets anyway, give them somewhere better to be.

So towns started throwing Halloween parties. Parades. Costume contests with prizes. Haunted houses in school gyms and church basements. Look at this one, from a small town in Washington State. And at home, people started keeping a bowl of treats by the front door.

The kids had a name for the arrangement. The phrase "trick or treat" shows up in Canadian newspapers in the 1920s. In 1927, a paper in Alberta reported kids at the back door and the front, "demanding edible plunder by the word 'trick or treat.'"

[dry] Edible plunder.

And the same report has the town out the next morning, hunting for its wagons. Wagons again. By the 1930s, the phrase was spreading across the United States.

So listen to the words one more time. "Trick or treat" isn't a greeting. *It's a deal.* Give me something, or else. It's a **protection racket**, with better costumes.

And mostly, it worked. A kid busy filling a bag isn't busy tipping over your outhouse.

Then, right as the deal was catching on, America ran out of sugar.

4:59 Sugar Goes to War

This is a ration book from World War Two. In the spring of 1942, sugar became the first food America **rationed**, meaning each family could only buy a set amount. And it was the last food to come off the list, in 1947. That's five Halloweens with hardly any candy.

So Halloween got pulled way back. Kids were told that pranks helped the enemy. The soap you'd smear on a window, the grease you'd put on the tracks? The war needed those. Some towns held scrap-metal drives on Halloween night instead.

And Chicago went further. In 1942, its city council voted to cancel Halloween for the rest of the war. [wry] Whether anybody actually told the kids is a different question.

Then the war ended. Sugar came back, and so did the soldiers. Then came the **baby boom**: millions of new kids, growing up in brand-new

suburbs where the houses sat close together, every front door a few steps from the next. If you're five years old with a pillowcase, that's not a neighborhood. That's a buffet.

Candy companies noticed. Kids' magazines ran trick-or-treat stories. Even Donald Duck got a trick-or-treat cartoon. By the early 1950s, Halloween belonged to little kids.

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[warmly] Quick thing before we go on. If you're enjoying this, hit subscribe. It's free, and unlike 1943, I'm not asking for your sugar.

Halloween had never been safer. Which is exactly when parents got scared.

6:26 The Night in Texas (quiet chapter)

[serious] Halloween, 1974. A suburb outside Houston, Texas. An eight-year-old boy goes trick-or-treating with his sister and some friends.

That night, before bed, he eats a candy straw from his bag. Within an hour, he's dead. It was laced with cyanide, a deadly poison.

His father told police that a stranger at a dark house must have handed it out. The whole country heard that story.

[pause] But there was no stranger. The poison came from his father. He was deep in debt, and he'd taken out life insurance on his children. He was convicted of murder, and executed almost ten years later.

That's the night in Texas from the beginning of this video.

But the fear had already spread, and it kept growing. Hospitals offered to X-ray kids' candy. Parents threw out apples and anything homemade. Every October, the same warning: check the candy, and don't trust strangers.

[serious] So here's the question. How many kids has a stranger's Halloween candy actually hurt?

How do we know? One sociologist has tracked newspaper reports of poisoned or tampered Halloween treats since 1958. That's almost seventy years, and about 130 reports. Most turned out to be hoaxes, or a pin found before anyone was hurt.

And he has never found a single child killed or seriously hurt by candy from a stranger. The one boy who really was poisoned by Halloween candy was poisoned by his own father.

The fear stuck anyway, and it got a fix of its own. Factory-wrapped candy only. Parents walking along behind. Trunk-or-treat in church parking lots. Another scare. Another fix. Another tradition.

So was any of this a good idea? It depends who you ask.

8:09 Treat or Shakedown?

Not everybody liked the deal, even back then. In 1948, a letter to the Washington Post said trick-or-treating was "making gangsters of children." The writer wanted the city to fine parents who sent their kids out to beg.

[wry] And honestly? She had a point. We did just spend this whole video calling it a protection racket.

But to towns that had been using tear gas on teenagers fifteen years earlier, it looked like a miracle. The streets got quieter. Kids got a safe night out. Both of those things were true at once.

[thoughtful] So let's go back to the question. How did the most destructive night of the year turn into a candy holiday for little kids?

The turnip crossed the ocean and turned into a pumpkin. The pranks got worse, until police used tear gas. So towns made a deal: treats at the door, and leave the house alone. The war took the sugar. The suburbs

gave it back. And a scare that began with a lie in Texas wrapped it all in plastic.

Every time grown-ups got scared of Halloween, they invented a fix. *And every fix became the tradition.*

So that headline from 1933 isn't the opposite of trick-or-treating. *It's the reason for it.*

[dry] So when a kid knocks on your door this Saturday and says "trick or treat," you might want to pay up.

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[warmly] Thanks for watching. If you want more stories like this one, subscribe, and I'll see you next time.